

BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT · SALES

The Deal Cycle

Discovery, Negotiation & Closing — a first-principles field guide for turning a booked meeting into signed, happy, renewing customers.

Beginner track · Indian B2B & fintech context · Scripts, role-plays & cheat-sheets included · No prior sales experience assumed

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1. How a Deal Actually Moves: The Six Stages After the Meeting

Getting a meeting booked is the end of *prospecting*. It is the **start** of the deal cycle. A common beginner mistake is to treat the first meeting as the finish line and then pitch hard for a "yes". Real deals move through predictable stages, and your job is to move the buyer from one stage to the next — never to skip ahead. Think of it like a metro line: you cannot get off at the last station without passing through the ones in between.

The six stages after a meeting is booked are:

- **Discovery** — you diagnose the buyer's situation, problems, and priorities. You listen far more than you talk. Output: a clear, agreed understanding of the pain and the "why change".
- **Solution / Demo** — you show *only the parts of your product that map to the pain you uncovered*. Output: the buyer can see themselves using it and getting a result.
- **Proposal / Quote** — you put scope, outcomes, timeline and price on paper. Output: a document a champion can circulate internally.
- **Negotiation** — you and the buyer align on terms, price, and conditions. Output: agreement both sides can defend.
- **Close** — the paperwork is signed (purchase order, contract, or e-mandate). Output: a customer, and a start date.
- **Handoff** — you transfer the account cleanly to onboarding / customer success (CS). Output: a customer who gets value fast and does not regret buying.

The Deal Cycle (one line)

Meeting booked → **Discovery** → **Solution/Demo** → **Proposal/Quote** → **Negotiation** → **Close** → **Handoff** → (Renewal & Referral)

where: each arrow requires a clear "next step" agreed with the buyer before the call ends. A deal with no next step is a stalled deal.

Why stages matter to a beginner. Stages give you a map so you always know "where am I, and what is the one thing I must achieve on this call?" They also make your pipeline honest: a deal is only at the "Proposal" stage if a proposal has actually been sent and the economic buyer has seen it — not because you feel optimistic. In Indian B2B fintech sales cycles typically run 4–12 weeks for SMB (small & medium business) deals and 3–9 months for enterprise (large banks, NBFCs — Non-Banking Financial Companies), so discipline about stages is what keeps you sane over a long cycle.

Common trap — skipping discovery to demo faster: Beginners feel productive when they demo. But demoing before discovery means you show generic features, the buyer sees no relevance, and you lose control of the conversation. Every minute of discovery skipped costs you three minutes of objection handling later. Earn the right to present by diagnosing first.

Key takeaways: The deal cycle is a sequence of stages, each with a specific output and a required "next step". Your job is to advance the deal one stage at a time, not to force a close. A pipeline is only honest when stage = evidence, not optimism.

2. Discovery & Needs Analysis: The Heart of the Sale

If you learn only one thing from this guide, learn to run great discovery. **Discovery is the structured conversation where you diagnose the buyer's situation before you prescribe anything.** A doctor who prescribes medicine before examining you is dangerous; a salesperson who pitches before diagnosing is annoying and ineffective. The prescription (your product) is only as good as the diagnosis (your discovery).

2.1 What you are actually trying to learn

Great discovery uncovers five things, which you can remember as **SPPBD** — Situation, Problem, Pain, Business impact, Decision:

- **Situation** — the current state: what tools, processes, team, and volumes exist today. ("How do you handle merchant onboarding KYC today?")
- **Problem** — what is not working in that current state. ("KYC takes 3 days manually.")
- **Pain** — the emotional and operational cost of the problem. ("We lose ~15% of merchants who drop off during those 3 days.")
- **Business impact** — the rupee value of the pain. ("15% drop-off × 2,000 merchants/month × ₹1,200 average revenue = a big number.")
- **Decision** — how a purchase would actually get approved: budget, authority, timeline, process.

2.2 The listen-to-talk ratio

In a good discovery call, the buyer talks 60–70% of the time. Recorded-call research from platforms like Gong consistently shows top performers talk *less* and ask better questions. As a beginner your instinct is to fill silence and to prove you know the product. Resist it. Your value in discovery is your questions and your listening, not your monologue.

Common trap — talking too much (happy ears): Nervous beginners talk to relieve their own anxiety, and they hear a polite "sounds interesting" as a buying signal ("happy ears"). Every time you feel the urge to explain a feature, ask a question instead. Aim for the buyer doing most of the talking; if you finish a call having learned nothing new, you did not run discovery — you ran a monologue.

2.3 Uncovering pain (the core skill)

People buy to move *away from pain* more reliably than to move toward gain — loss aversion is real. Your job is to help the buyer articulate the pain in their own words and quantify it. You are not manufacturing pain that does not exist (that is manipulation); you are helping a buyer see the full cost of a problem they already have. This is the difference between selling and mis-selling, and it matters even more in financial services.

Key takeaways: Discovery = diagnosis before prescription. Learn Situation, Problem, Pain, Business impact, Decision. Let the buyer talk 60–70%. Help them quantify their own pain in rupees; never invent pain that isn't there.

3. Question Types: Open, Probing, SPIN & the Pain Funnel

Questions are your primary tool. Knowing the *types* lets you deliberately steer a conversation instead of hoping it goes well.

3.1 Open vs closed questions

- **Open questions** invite a story and cannot be answered with yes/no. They start with what, how, why, tell me, walk me through. Use these to open topics and get the buyer talking. Example: "Walk me through what happens today when a merchant's payout fails."
- **Closed questions** get a specific fact or confirmation. They start with is, do, are, how many, when. Use these to pin down numbers and to confirm understanding. Example: "How many failed payouts do you see in a typical month?"

Rule of thumb: **open to explore, closed to confirm**. A beginner mistake is asking only closed questions, which turns discovery into an interrogation that feels like a form-filling exercise.

3.2 Probing / layering questions

A probing question digs one level deeper into an answer the buyer just gave. This is where the gold is. When the buyer says something interesting, do not move on — layer.

- "You said onboarding is 'painful' — painful in what way, specifically?"
- "What have you already tried to fix that?"
- "What happens if this stays the same for another 12 months?"
- "Who else feels this pain besides you?"

3.3 SPIN questioning (Neil Rackham)

SPIN is a research-backed sequence of four question types — Situation, Problem, Implication, Need-payoff — developed by Neil Rackham from analysing 35,000 sales calls. It is the single best framework for a beginner to internalise because it builds pain logically.

SPIN — the four question types, in order

S — Situation: understand the current facts. "How do you run collections today?"

P — Problem: surface a difficulty or dissatisfaction. "Where does that process break down?"

I — Implication: expand the consequences of the problem. "What does that delay cost you in a quarter?"

N — Need-payoff: let the buyer state the value of solving it. "If you could cut that delay in half, what would that mean for the team?"

where: Implication questions make the pain *bigger and more urgent*; Need-payoff questions make the buyer sell themselves on the solution. Beginners over-ask Situation questions (boring, they could have researched) and under-ask Implication questions (the ones that create urgency).

Why the order matters. Situation and Problem questions surface the pain; Implication questions *grow* it; Need-payoff questions let the buyer articulate the value in their own words — which is far more persuasive than you claiming it. When a buyer says "If we cut KYC to under an hour, we'd probably save 15% of our drop-off," they have just built your business case for you.

3.4 The Pain Funnel

The **Pain Funnel** (popularised by the Sandler sales method) is a specific sequence of questions that takes a vague complaint and drives it down to a concrete, quantified, personal pain. You start wide and narrow down.

The Pain Funnel — question ladder (top to bottom)

1. "Tell me more about that..."
2. "Can you be more specific? Give me an example."
3. "How long has this been a problem?"
4. "What have you tried to do about it?"
5. "And did that work?"
6. "How much do you think it has cost you?" (money / time)
7. "How do *you* feel about that personally?"
8. "Have you given up trying to solve it?"

where: each rung makes the pain more specific and more personal. By the bottom, the buyer has told you (a) the problem is real, (b) it is expensive, (c) their past fixes failed, and (d) they personally care. That is a qualified, motivated buyer.

Mini role-play — walking down the Pain Funnel (fintech collections)

Rep: "You mentioned recovery rates are 'not great'. Tell me more about that."

Buyer: "Our field collection team is chasing EMIs manually, so a lot slips."

Rep: "Can you be specific — what's your current 90+ day delinquency?"

Buyer: "Around 6%, up from 4% last year."

Rep: "How long has it been climbing?"

Buyer: "About three quarters now."

Rep: "What have you tried?"

Buyer: "We hired more field agents, but cost went up and it barely moved."

Rep: "On a ₹500 crore book, what does that 2% swing cost you?"

Buyer: "...honestly, close to ₹10 crore in provisioning. It's why my COO is on my case."

Rep: "So it's not just a numbers problem — it's landing on you personally?"

Buyer: "Every review, yes."

Notice: the rep never pitched. The buyer went from "not great" to "₹10 crore and my boss is on me" in eight questions. That is a deal worth pursuing, and the buyer built the urgency himself.

Key takeaways: Open to explore, closed to confirm, probe to go deeper. Learn SPIN and over-invest in Implication questions (they create urgency). Use the Pain Funnel to convert vague complaints into quantified, personal pain — in the buyer's own words.

4. Qualification: BANT, MEDDIC & the Decision Process

Qualification is deciding whether a deal is *real and winnable* before you pour weeks into it. Not every interested person is a buyer. Two frameworks matter for a beginner.

4.1 BANT

BANT — the classic qualifier

B — Budget: is there money, and roughly how much? "Is there a budget allocated for this, or would we be creating one?"

A — Authority: who signs? "Besides yourself, who else weighs in on a decision like this?"

N — Need: is the pain real and prioritised? (Your discovery answers this.)

T — Timeline: when do they need it live? "What's driving the timing — is there a date this has to be solved by?"

where: BANT is a checklist, not a script. You weave these into a natural conversation, never fire them like a form. A deal missing any of the four is a risk you must name.

4.2 MEDDIC (for larger / enterprise deals)

MEDDIC is a heavier qualifier used for complex enterprise deals (e.g., selling to a large bank or NBFC). Acronym: **M**etrics (the quantified value), **E**conomic buyer (the one person who can say yes and release budget), **D**ecision criteria (what they will judge vendors on), **D**ecision process (the actual steps: legal, InfoSec, procurement, board), **I**dentify pain, **C**hampion (an insider who wants you to win and has influence).

4.3 Mapping the decision process

In Indian enterprise fintech deals, the buying group is large: a business sponsor, IT/InfoSec (information security), risk & compliance, legal, and procurement. Ask early: "Walk me through how a decision like this typically gets approved here — who's involved, and roughly how long does each step take?" This single question saves you from the number-one deal killer: discovering a procurement or InfoSec gate *after* you thought you had won.

Common trap — ignoring the decision-maker (single-threading): Beginners get comfortable with one friendly contact and never meet the person who actually signs. This is "single-threading" and it is how deals die when your one contact changes jobs or gets overruled. Always ask "who else needs to be comfortable with this?" and get to the economic buyer and the champion. Multi-thread.

Key takeaways: Qualify with BANT (budget, authority, need, timeline) for most deals; MEDDIC for enterprise. Map the full buying group and decision process early. Never single-thread — reach the economic buyer and build a champion.

5. The Discovery Call Script & Checklist

Here is a complete, adaptable script for a 30-minute first discovery call. Do not read it robotically — internalise the flow. The structure is **Open → Agenda → Discover → Confirm → Next step**.

Full discovery-call script (fintech, ~30 min)**1. Rapport & frame (2 min).**

"Thanks for the time, Priya. Before we dive in — how's your quarter going with the new lending product launch I read about?" (*genuine, researched, brief*)

2. Set the agenda & get permission (1 min).

"Here's what I'd suggest for the next 30 minutes: I'd love to understand how you handle merchant onboarding and collections today and where it's getting in your way. If it looks like we can help, I'll show you exactly how — if not, I'll tell you that honestly. And I want to leave 5 minutes at the end to agree on a sensible next step. Does that work? Anything you want to add to the agenda?"

3. Situation questions (5 min).

"Walk me through your merchant onboarding flow today, from application to first transaction." · "Roughly how many merchants a month?" · "Which tools/teams are involved?"

4. Problem & Pain Funnel (10 min).

"Where does that break down most?" · "Tell me more about the drop-off — can you quantify it?" · "How long has that been a problem?" · "What have you tried?" · "Did it work?" · "What's that costing you?" · "How does that land with your leadership?"

5. Implication & Need-payoff (5 min).

"If this stays as-is through the festive peak, what happens?" · "If onboarding dropped from 3 days to 3 hours, what would that unlock for you?"

6. Qualify — decision & timeline (3 min).

"Is fixing this a priority this quarter, or a 'someday'?" · "What's driving the timing?" · "If we go ahead, who else would need to be comfortable — IT, risk, procurement?" · "Is there budget set aside, or would we build a case for it?"

7. Confirm & summarise (2 min).

"Let me play back what I heard: onboarding takes 3 days, you lose ~15% of merchants, it's worse in peak season, and it's costing roughly ₹X a month. Did I get that right? Anything I missed?"

8. Agree the next step (2 min).

"Based on this, the useful next step is a 40-minute working session where I show you exactly how we'd cut onboarding to under an hour, with your risk lead in the room. Does Thursday or Friday suit? I'll send an agenda so it's worth everyone's time."

Discovery checklist (tick before you end the call)

- ☐ I understand their current process and the numbers behind it.
- ☐ I have at least one quantified pain (rupees, hours, or % lost).
- ☐ I know why now / what's driving urgency.
- ☐ I know who else is involved in the decision.
- ☐ I have a sense of budget (exists / must be built).
- ☐ I played the pain back and the buyer agreed.
- ☐ I have a specific, dated next step on the calendar.

Common trap — ending with "I'll send you some information": That is not a next step; it is a polite exit that kills momentum. Always leave a discovery call with a specific, dated commitment (a working session, a demo with named attendees). Vague next steps = dead deals.

Key takeaways: Structure every discovery call as Open → Agenda → Discover → Confirm → Next step. Get permission for the agenda, run the Pain Funnel, qualify the decision, play back the pain, and always leave with a dated next step.

6. Value Proposition & Solution Presentation (FAB)

Now you have diagnosed. Only now do you present — and only the parts that matter. The core tool is **FAB: Features, Advantages, Benefits**. Beginners sell features; professionals sell benefits tied to the buyer's specific pain.

FAB — Features, Advantages, Benefits

Feature: a fact about the product — what it *is*. ("Our API does Aadhaar-based eKYC.")

Advantage: what the feature *does* — the generic capability. ("So identity verification is instant instead of manual.")

Benefit: what it means *for this buyer's pain* — the outcome they care about. ("Which means you cut onboarding from 3 days to under an hour and recover most of that 15% drop-off — roughly ₹X a month.")

where: a Feature answers "what is it?", an Advantage answers "what does it do?", a Benefit answers "why do I care?". The Benefit must connect to a pain you actually uncovered in discovery. A benefit with no matching pain is just noise.

The bridge word. Link feature to benefit with "which means...". "We support UPI Autopay mandates *which means* your recurring collections auto-debit on due date *which means* your DPD-o (days-past-due) collection rate goes up without adding field agents." The phrase forces you off features and onto outcomes.

6.1 Tailoring to persona

The same feature has different benefits for different people. Tailor:

Persona	What they care about	Benefit framing for "instant eKYC"
CFO / Finance head	Cost, revenue, risk, ROI	"Recovers ₹X/month of lost merchant revenue; payback under 4 months."
Head of Ops	Efficiency, headcount, SLAs	"Cuts manual review workload 70%; your team stops firefighting."
Risk / Compliance	Regulatory safety, audit trail	"Full RBI-compliant audit log; reduces KYC error rate and audit findings."
CTO / IT	Integration, security, uptime	"REST API, 99.9% uptime, SOC 2 & ISO 27001; go live in 2 weeks."

6.2 A short value pitch for a fintech product

FAB value pitch — a merchant-onboarding & KYC platform

"Priya, based on what you told me — 3-day onboarding, 15% drop-off, worst during peak — here's the one thing I'd want you to see."

Feature: "Our platform runs Aadhaar eKYC, PAN verification, and bank-account penny-drop checks in a single API call."

Advantage: "So instead of your ops team collecting documents over email and verifying manually across three days, verification happens in seconds while the merchant is still in the flow."

Benefit (tied to her pain): "Which means onboarding drops from 3 days to under an hour, you stop losing that 15% who give up waiting, and during the festive peak you can onboard 3x the merchants with the same team. On your volumes that's roughly ₹X a month in recovered revenue — and your ops head stops firefighting."

Proof: "An NBFC lender your size did exactly this last year and took drop-off from 14% to 4% in one quarter. I can introduce you if useful."

That's it — 45 seconds, one feature, tied to her exact numbers, with proof. Not a 40-slide feature dump.

Common trap — feature-dumping / the demo firehose: Showing every feature to prove the product is powerful actually dilutes your message and creates objections ("we don't need half of this, why pay for it?"). Show the two or three things that solve *their* pain, and stop. Less is more persuasive.

Key takeaways: Sell benefits, not features. Use FAB and the bridge "which means...". Tailor the benefit to each persona. Anchor every benefit to a pain you actually uncovered, and back it with proof. Show less, connect more.

7. Storytelling, ROI & the Business Case

7.1 Why stories beat statistics

Numbers inform; stories persuade and stick. The most powerful sales story is the **before–after–bridge** customer story: a company like theirs (before) had the same pain; they adopted your solution (bridge); now they have a better outcome (after). Keep it 60–90 seconds, specific, and relevant to the buyer's segment. "A ₹500-crore-book NBFC just like you was at 6% delinquency; they rolled out our auto-collections; two quarters later they were at 4% with a smaller field team." Use real, permissioned references — never fabricate a case study.

7.2 ROI and business-case selling

ROI (Return on Investment) selling means expressing your price as a fraction of the value delivered, so the buyer sees a return, not a cost. The math a beginner must be able to do on a whiteboard:

Simple ROI framing

Net annual value = (Annual gain from solving the pain) – (Annual cost of the solution)

ROI % = Net annual value ÷ Annual cost × 100

Payback period (months) = Annual cost ÷ (Monthly gain)

where: "gain" = revenue recovered + cost saved + risk avoided. If your product costs ₹12 lakh/year and recovers ₹60 lakh/year of lost revenue, ROI = $(60-12)/12 = 400\%$, payback ≈ 2.4 months. Always let the buyer supply the input numbers so they own the result.

Worked business case — building it with the buyer

Rep: "Let's do the math together so it's your numbers, not mine. You onboard ~2,000 merchants a month and lose 15% to slow KYC — that's 300 lost merchants."

Buyer: "Roughly, yes."

Rep: "And each merchant is worth about ₹1,200/month in revenue to you?"

Buyer: "About that."

Rep: "So $300 \times ₹1,200 = ₹3.6$ lakh/month, ₹43 lakh/year of lost revenue. If we recover even two-thirds of that, it's ~₹29 lakh/year. Our platform is ₹12 lakh/year. So you're spending 12 to recover 29 — a bit over 2x in year one, payback in about 5 months. Does that math feel fair to you, or too optimistic?"

Buyer: "Two-thirds is fair, maybe conservative."

Rep: "Then we're being conservative and it still pays back in 5 months. That's the case I'd take to your CFO."

Notice the rep asks "does that feel fair?" — inviting the buyer to challenge the assumptions makes the final number *theirs*, which they will defend internally to their CFO. A business case the buyer co-built is far stronger than a slick ROI slide you made alone.

Key takeaways: Persuade with a short, relevant, true customer story (before–after–bridge). Sell ROI by expressing price as a fraction of value, using the buyer's own numbers. Co-build the business case so the champion can defend it to the CFO.

8. Running a Demo That Sells

A demo is not a product tour; it is a **tailored proof that you can solve the pain you uncovered**. The best demos follow "tell–show–tell": tell them what you'll show and why it matters to them, show it, then tell them what they just saw in terms of their outcome.

8.1 The demo structure

- **Recap the pain (30 sec).** "Last time you said onboarding takes 3 days and you lose 15%. Today I'll show three things: instant eKYC, the risk dashboard your compliance lead asked about, and the merchant experience."
- **Lead with the "wow" that maps to pain.** Show the biggest pain-solver first, not your login screen. Attention is highest at the start.
- **Show, then pause and check.** After each key moment: "How does that compare to your current flow?" Keep it a conversation, not a monologue.
- **Use their data / their language.** If you can, put their brand, their merchant type, their volumes into the demo. Relevance beats polish.
- **Handle "can it also...?" carefully.** Answer honestly; if it can't, say so and note it. Never fake capability.
- **Close the demo with a trial close.** "Assuming security review passes, is there anything you've seen that would stop this from working for you?"

Common trap — the unstructured "let me show you everything" demo: Wandering menus, tangents, and 45 features shown to prove power. The buyer disengages by minute 10. Demo three things that solve their pain, check in after each, and stop early rather than late. A tight 20-minute demo beats a rambling 60-minute one.

Key takeaways: A demo proves you solve *their* pain — it is not a feature tour. Recap the pain, lead with the biggest pain-solver, use their data and language, pause to check after each moment, and end with a trial close.

9. Proposals, Pricing & Ethical Urgency

9.1 Proposal structure

A proposal is a document your champion uses to sell internally when you are not in the room. Make it easy to circulate and hard to argue with. A clean structure:

1. **Executive summary** — their situation, their pain, the outcome, in their words. (One page a busy CFO can read alone.)
2. **Objectives & success metrics** — the numbers you agreed (e.g., onboarding <1 hr, drop-off <5%).
3. **Proposed solution & scope** — exactly what's included (and what's not, to prevent scope creep).
4. **Business case / ROI** — the co-built math from Section 7.
5. **Timeline & implementation plan** — go-live date, milestones, responsibilities.
6. **Commercials / pricing** — clear, with options if relevant.
7. **Proof** — relevant case study, references, security certifications.

8. **Next steps** — the exact path to signature.

9.2 Presenting price with confidence

Beginners fear the price moment and undermine it: they mumble the number, apologise, or immediately offer a discount before the buyer even reacts. Do the opposite. State the price clearly, tie it to value, and then **stay silent**. "The platform is ₹12 lakh a year, which against the ~₹29 lakh you'd recover is a little over 2x return in year one." Then stop talking. The first person to speak after the price often concedes; let it be the buyer.

Common trap — discounting before you're asked: Offering a discount to pre-empt an objection signals your price isn't real and trains the buyer to expect more. Never discount unprompted. Present price with conviction and let silence do the work.

9.3 Pricing presentation tactics (ethical)

- **Anchor high, then options.** Present the full-value package first; then a good/better/best set. Buyers dislike extremes and gravitate to the middle.
- **Price on value, not cost.** Frame annual price against annual value, and break big numbers into per-unit ("that's about ₹40 per merchant onboarded").
- **Bundle vs unbundle deliberately.** Bundling hides line-item haggling; unbundling shows value drivers. Use each on purpose.

9.4 Creating urgency — ethically

Urgency should come from *the buyer's* world, not fake pressure. Ethical urgency:

- **Real business events:** "You said festive peak starts in 8 weeks and onboarding takes 2 weeks to go live — so a decision by month-end keeps you live before the rush."
- **Cost of delay:** "Every month at 15% drop-off is ~₹3.6 lakh gone. Waiting a quarter costs ~₹11 lakh."
- **Genuine, honoured limited offers:** a real end-of-quarter incentive you will actually honour and not repeat next week.

Common trap — fake scarcity: "This price is only valid today" when it isn't, or inventing a phantom other buyer. It works once, then destroys trust and, in financial services, can cross into mis-selling. Urgency must be true. Use the buyer's real deadlines and the real cost of delay.

Key takeaways: Write the proposal so a champion can sell it without you. State price clearly, tie to value, then stay silent. Anchor high with good/better/best. Create urgency only from real events and real cost-of-delay — never fake scarcity.

10. The Psychology of Objections

An objection is not rejection — it is **engagement**. A buyer who objects is still in the conversation; a buyer who says "sounds great, I'll get back to you" and vanishes is the real problem. Reframe objections as requests for more information or reassurance.

10.1 What objections really mean

- **Price objections** are usually value objections in disguise — the buyer doesn't yet see enough value to justify the number.
- **"Need to think"** usually means an unspoken concern, a missing stakeholder, or no real urgency.
- **"No budget"** may mean no budget *allocated* — but budget can be created for a strong enough business case.
- **"Happy with current"** often means the pain of change feels bigger than the pain of staying. Your job is to shift that balance honestly.

10.2 The mindset

Stay calm and curious, never defensive. An objection you handle well builds more trust than a smooth pitch with no friction. The worst response is to argue — you cannot win a deal by winning an argument. Seek to understand the objection fully before you respond; often the first objection is not the real one.

Key takeaways: Objections signal engagement, not rejection. Price objections are usually hidden value objections; "think about it" usually hides a specific concern. Stay curious, never defensive — you cannot win a deal by winning an argument.

11. A Repeatable Objection Method + Cheat-Sheet

You need one method you can run under pressure without thinking. Two well-known ones, then a combined one.

11.1 LAER

LAER — Listen, Acknowledge, Explore, Respond

Listen: hear the whole objection without interrupting.

Acknowledge: validate it. "That's a fair concern."

Explore: ask a question to find the real issue. "When you say expensive — compared to what?"

Respond: address the *real* issue, then confirm you resolved it.

where: most beginners jump straight to Respond and answer the wrong objection. Explore is the step that separates pros from amateurs — it uncovers the true concern behind the stated one.

11.2 Feel–Felt–Found

A gentle, empathetic pattern, especially good for emotional or "happy with current" objections: "I understand how you **feel**. Other heads of ops **felt** the same about switching. What they **found** after go-live was that migration took two weeks and drop-off halved." Use sparingly — it's become well-known, so keep it genuine, not scripted-sounding.

11.3 The method I recommend: Acknowledge → Clarify → Respond → Confirm

ACRC — the four-step objection response

1. **Acknowledge** — lower the temperature. "Totally fair to raise that."
2. **Clarify** — ask a question to understand the real concern. "Help me understand — is it the total number, or the budget timing?"
3. **Respond** — address the real concern with value/proof. Reframe to ROI.
4. **Confirm** — check you resolved it and move forward. "Does that address it? Anything else on your mind?"

where: never skip Clarify. The stated objection ("too expensive") and the real one ("I'm not sure this will actually work") are often different. Confirm turns a resolved objection into forward momentum.

Objection handling in action — "It's too expensive"

Buyer: "Honestly, it's too expensive."

Rep (Acknowledge): "Fair — it's a real investment and you should push on it."

Rep (Clarify): "Help me understand: is it that the total is more than you expected, or is it a budget-timing issue this quarter?"

Buyer: "It's more than we budgeted."

Rep (Respond): "Got it. Let's look at it against the return, not in isolation. It's ₹12 lakh, and by your own numbers it recovers about ₹29 lakh a year — so it pays for itself in roughly 5 months and is net-positive after that. The real question isn't 'can we afford ₹12 lakh', it's 'can we afford to keep losing ₹29 lakh'. If budget timing is tight, we can also start with a quarterly plan or phase the rollout. Which would help more?"

Rep (Confirm): "If we solve the budget-timing piece, is there anything else standing between us and moving forward?"

11.4 Objection → Response Cheat-Sheet

Objection	What it usually means	Model response (short)
"It's too expensive"	Value not yet clear	"Compared to what? Against the ₹29 lakh it recovers, it pays back in ~5 months. Is it the total, or the timing?"
"We have no budget"	No budget <i>allocated</i> yet	"Understood — most of our clients built the budget once the business case was clear. If I help you build that case for your CFO, would you take it forward?"
"We're happy with our current provider"	Change feels riskier than staying	"Great that it's working. Out of curiosity, if you could improve one thing about it, what would it be? ... Worth a 20-min look at just that gap?"
"Just send me an email / some info"	Brush-off or low urgency	"Happy to — so I send the right thing and not a generic deck, can I ask two quick questions?" (re-engage into discovery)
"I need to think about it"	Unspoken concern or missing stakeholder	"Of course. So I'm useful — what specifically do you want to think through? Usually it's price, fit, or timing. Which is it?"
"Call me back next quarter"	Not a priority / no cost-of-delay felt	"Sure. Just so I understand — what changes next quarter that makes this a yes? And what does waiting a quarter cost you at 15% drop-off?"
"Your competitor is cheaper"	Comparing on price, not value	"They might be. Can I ask what they include? Often the gap is [X] — which for you is worth ₹Y. Let's compare total value, not just sticker price."
"We need to build this in-house"	Underestimating cost/time of DIY	"You could. Realistically that's ~6 months of engineering plus compliance upkeep. We're live in 2 weeks. What's your team's opportunity cost of those 6 months?"
"Send it to procurement"	Real step, or a soft deflection	"Happy to. Before I do — are you personally comfortable this is the right fit? I want procurement negotiating a deal you already want."

Common trap — happy ears + arguing: Two opposite failures. Either you ignore the objection and hear a "yes" that isn't there, or you argue and try to prove the buyer wrong. Both lose. Acknowledge, clarify the real concern, respond with value, and confirm. Curiosity beats combat.

Key takeaways: Run one method under pressure: Acknowledge → Clarify → Respond → Confirm. Always Clarify before you Respond — the stated objection is rarely the real one. Memorise the cheat-sheet, but adapt it to what discovery told you.

12. Negotiation: Interests, BATNA, ZOPA, Anchoring & Concessions

Negotiation begins when both sides want a deal and are settling terms. Amateurs think negotiation is about price; professionals know it's about **trading value** to reach an agreement both sides will defend. The foundational text is *Getting to Yes* (Fisher & Ury) — principled negotiation.

12.1 Interests vs positions

A **position** is what someone *says they want* ("I need a 20% discount"). An **interest** is *why* they want it ("I have a fixed budget cap" or "I need a win to show my boss"). Positions clash; interests can often be reconciled. Always dig from position to interest: "Help me understand what's driving the 20% — is it the total budget, a per-user cost, or something you need to show internally?" The 20% discount and "a win to show my boss" have very different solutions.

12.2 Negotiation terms every beginner must know

Term	Full form / meaning	In one line
BATNA	Best Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement	What you'll do if this deal falls through. Your walk-away power. Know yours <i>and</i> theirs.
ZOPA	Zone Of Possible Agreement	The overlap between the most you'd accept and the least they'd accept. If it exists, a deal is possible.
Reservation price	Walk-away point	The worst term you'll still say yes to. Set it before you negotiate; never reveal it.
Anchor	The first number on the table	Sets the frame for everything after. Whoever anchors credibly pulls the outcome toward them.
Concession	Something you give up	Never give one without getting something back. Trade, don't gift.
Log-rolling	Trading across issues	Give on what's cheap to you but valuable to them; take on what's valuable to you.

12.3 Anchoring

The first credible number shapes the whole negotiation (the anchoring bias). This is why you present full value/price first, before any discount talk. If the buyer anchors low ("we only pay ₹5 lakh for this kind of thing"), don't accept their frame — re-anchor to value: "I understand that's a reference point; the reason ours is priced where it is is the ₹29 lakh it recovers. Let's talk about the return." Never let a lowball anchor go unchallenged; silence looks like agreement.

12.4 Trading concessions — never give without getting

The golden rule of sales negotiation: **every concession you make must be traded for something of value**. If you drop price, get something: a longer term, a case study, a reference, faster payment, a bigger scope, a public logo. This does two things — it protects margin, and it teaches the buyer that concessions are earned, so they stop pushing endlessly.

The concession trade — "If... then..."

"If you can commit to a 2-year term and be a reference client, **then** I can get you 10% off."

"If you can pay annually upfront instead of quarterly, **then** I can include the premium support tier."

where: the "if/then" structure makes the trade explicit. You never say "okay, 10% off" — you say "if you do X, then 10%". Give reluctantly and in shrinking amounts, so each concession feels final.

12.5 A worked negotiation scenario

Negotiation role-play — the ₹12 lakh deal, buyer wants 25% off

Buyer (anchor): "We like it, but we can only do this at ₹9 lakh — that's 25% off. Take it or leave it."

Rep (don't react to the anchor; explore the interest): "I appreciate you being direct. Help me understand the ₹9 lakh — is that a hard budget ceiling, or a target you've been asked to hit?"

Buyer: "Procurement has capped new-vendor spend at ₹10 lakh this year."

Rep (now knows the real interest — a ₹10 lakh ceiling, not 25%): "Got it — so the real constraint is the ₹10 lakh cap, not the specific number. That I can work with. But I can't just cut 20% for nothing; my team would ask what we got in return. So here's a fair trade."

Rep (trade concessions): "If you sign a 2-year term — which fits your cap because year one lands at ₹10 lakh — **and** agree to be a reference for other NBFCs, **then** I can bring year one to ₹10 lakh and hold year two flat. You stay under the cap, I protect the relationship's value. Fair?"

Buyer: "Two years is a lot. Can we do it at ₹10 lakh for one year?"

Rep (shrinking concession, hold the line): "One year at ₹10 lakh I can't do — that's the same discount with none of the commitment that justifies it. But if two years feels long, let's do 18 months at ₹10 lakh/year with a break clause after year one. You get the cap, I get the commitment. That's the best I can structure."

Buyer: "...okay, 18 months with the break clause works. And the reference — fine, if you go live successfully."

Rep (confirm & close): "Deal. 18 months, ₹10 lakh/year, break clause after 12 months, you're a reference post-go-live. I'll send the paper today. Can we target signature by Friday to keep you live before peak?"

What happened: the rep never accepted the 25% anchor, uncovered the real interest (a ₹10 lakh cap), traded every rupee of discount for term and a reference, shrank the concession, and closed with a dated next step. Both sides got a defensible win.

Common trap — the discount trap / caving to close: Under deadline pressure, beginners give price away to "get it over the line", often unprompted and without trading. This trains buyers to always push, destroys your margin and your comp, and signals the original price was fake. Never discount without a trade, never discount to relieve your own anxiety, and shrink each concession so the buyer sees the well running dry.

Key takeaways: Negotiate interests, not positions. Know your BATNA and reservation price; look for the ZOPA. Don't accept a lowball anchor — re-anchor to value. Trade every concession with "if/then", give reluctantly and in shrinking amounts, and aim for a win both sides can defend.

13. Dealing with Procurement & the Discount Trap

In Indian enterprise deals (banks, large NBFCs, insurers), procurement is a specialist function whose job is to extract concessions. Do not take it personally — squeezing you is literally their KPI. Rules for a beginner:

- **Sell value before you ever reach procurement.** If the business sponsor already wants you, procurement negotiates a "how", not a "whether". Get your champion to fight for you internally.
- **Never make your first offer your best offer.** Procurement expects to negotiate; leave room so they get a "win" to report, without you losing your shirt.
- **Trade, never gift.** Same rule as Section 12: every rupee off buys you term, volume, a reference, or faster payment terms.
- **Protect your walk-away.** Know your reservation price and be willing to say "at that number, it doesn't work for us — here's what would." Buyers respect a credible walk-away.
- **Beware the "one more thing" nibble.** After agreement, procurement often asks for a last small concession ("throw in free training"). Counter-nibble or trade: "I can include training if we sign by Friday."

Key takeaways: Procurement's job is to squeeze — expect it, don't take it personally. Win the business sponsor first so procurement negotiates the how, not the whether. Leave negotiating room, trade every concession, protect your walk-away, and counter last-minute nibbles.

14. Closing: Buying Signals, Trial Closes & Techniques

Closing is not a magic trick at the end; it is the natural result of good discovery, a tied-to-pain solution, and handled objections. If you did those well, the close is quiet. Still, you must **ask for the business** — the number-one reason beginners lose winnable deals is that they never actually ask.

14.1 Reading buying signals

Buying signals tell you the buyer is leaning in. Watch and listen for:

- **Ownership language:** "how would *we* roll this out?", "when could *we* go live?"
- **Detail questions:** about implementation, onboarding, support SLAs, contract terms — people don't sweat details on things they won't buy.
- **Bringing in others:** "let me get my risk head on the next call."
- **Price/terms questions:** "is there flexibility on payment terms?"
- **Non-verbal (in person / video):** leaning forward, nodding, taking notes.

14.2 Trial closes

A **trial close** is a low-pressure question that tests temperature without asking for the final commitment. It surfaces objections early so nothing ambushes you at signature. Examples:

- "How are you feeling about this so far?"
- "On a scale of 1–10, how good a fit does this look?" (then: "what would make it a 10?")
- "If the security review passes, is there anything else that would stop us going ahead?"
- "Directionally, does this feel like the right solution for you?"

14.3 Closing techniques (used ethically)

Technique	How it works	Example (fintech)
Assumptive close	Proceed as if it's a yes, on next steps	"Great — I'll send the agreement today and we'll target go-live before peak. Who should I loop in for the technical kickoff?"
Summary close	Recap agreed value, then ask	"So: onboarding under an hour, drop-off from 15% to sub-5%, ₹29 lakh recovered, live in 2 weeks, pays back in 5 months. Shall we get started?"
Alternative (choice) close	Offer two yeses, not yes/no	"Would you prefer to start with the full rollout, or pilot with one merchant segment first?"
Urgency / event close	Tie to a real deadline	"To be live before the festive peak, we'd need to sign by month-end — shall we work to that?"
Direct ask	Simply ask for the business	"I think this is a strong fit. Are you ready to move forward?" (then stay silent)
Puppy-dog / pilot close	Let them try it low-risk	"Let's run a 30-day pilot on one segment. If it hits the numbers, we scale. Fair?"

Ethical line: these techniques help a buyer who wants to buy take the step. They are manipulation only if you use them to push someone into a purchase that isn't right for them. Never use urgency you invented or an alternative close to hide a bad fit. In financial services, that crosses into mis-selling (Section 17).

A full closing sequence — trial close → summary → alternative → ask

Rep (trial close): "Before we talk next steps — on a 1–10, how good a fit does this feel?"

Buyer: "Honestly, an 8."

Rep (surface the gap): "Good — what would make it a 10?"

Buyer: "Confidence the migration won't disrupt live merchants."

Rep (resolve): "Fair. We run a parallel-run for two weeks — old and new side by side, zero disruption, and we only cut over once you sign off. Does that take you to a 10?"

Buyer: "Yeah, that does."

Rep (summary close): "Then let's recap: onboarding under an hour, drop-off to sub-5%, ~₹29 lakh recovered, two-week parallel-run with zero disruption, live before peak, payback in about 5 months."

Rep (alternative close): "Would you rather kick off with the full rollout, or start with your top merchant segment and expand?"

Buyer: "Let's start with the top segment."

Rep (ask + silence): "Perfect. I'll send the agreement this afternoon for the segment rollout. If we sign by Friday, you're live before peak. Shall I go ahead?" (*then stops talking*)

Buyer: "Yes, send it across."

Common trap — never actually asking for the business: Beginners run a great process then end with "so... let me know what you think." That hands the buyer an easy exit and stalls the deal. You must explicitly ask — assumptive, alternative, or direct — and then be quiet. Silence after the ask is uncomfortable; sit in it. Whoever speaks first often concedes.

Key takeaways: Closing is the result of good discovery, not a trick. Read buying signals, use trial closes to surface objections early, and pick a closing technique that fits. Always explicitly ask for the business,

then stay silent. Techniques are ethical only when the fit is genuine.

15. Asking for the Business & the Mutual Action Plan

15.1 The Mutual Action Plan (MAP)

For anything beyond a small deal, don't rely on a vague "let's proceed". Build a **Mutual Action Plan** — a shared, dated checklist of every step from now to go-live, with owners on both sides. It de-risks the close, exposes hidden steps (InfoSec, legal, board approval), and creates mutual commitment.

Mutual Action Plan — columns

Step | Owner (us / them) | Due date | Status

where: typical rows for a fintech deal — security questionnaire, legal/MSA redlines, procurement negotiation, pilot sign-off, PO issuance, kickoff scheduled, go-live. Reviewing the MAP together each week keeps the deal moving and makes slippage visible early.

15.2 How to ask — the words

Keep it simple and confident. "Based on everything we've covered, I believe this is the right solution for you. I'd like to move forward — can we?" Then be silent. If you've earned it, the ask is easy; if it feels hard to ask, that usually means a stage upstream (discovery, value, an objection) is unfinished — go back and fix that rather than pushing harder on the close.

Key takeaways: Use a Mutual Action Plan for any non-trivial deal — shared, dated, owned steps to go-live. Ask for the business in plain, confident words, then stay silent. If asking feels hard, an earlier stage is incomplete.

16. Post-Close: Handoff, Referrals & Win/Loss Review

16.1 A clean handoff to onboarding / CS

The sale isn't done at signature — it's done when the customer gets value. A sloppy handoff creates buyer's remorse and churn. Do a proper transition to the onboarding / **CS (Customer Success)** team:

- **Internal handoff note:** the pain, the promised outcomes and metrics, key stakeholders, any commitments you made, and landmines. Never let CS "re-discover" everything — the customer hates repeating themselves.
- **Warm introduction:** personally introduce the CS owner on a call or email. "You're in great hands with Ravi, who'll get you live."
- **Honour your promises.** Anything you promised in the sale (a feature, a timeline) must be written down and delivered, or you have mis-sold.

16.2 Avoiding buyer's remorse

Post-purchase anxiety (cognitive dissonance) is normal, especially after a big-ticket B2B decision. Reduce it: send a reassuring note reaffirming the value and the plan, deliver a quick early win in onboarding, and stay reachable for the first few weeks. A confident, present seller after the sale prevents second-guessing and cancellations.

16.3 Referrals

A happy customer who has just seen a result is your best source of new pipeline. Ask at the moment of value, not randomly: "You mentioned the drop-off is down to 4% — I'm thrilled. Who else in your network is wrestling with the same onboarding problem? I'd love a warm introduction." Make it easy — offer to draft the intro message they can forward.

16.4 Win/Loss review — learning from every deal

Whether you win or lose, review it. This is how a beginner becomes good fast. Ask (ideally the buyer, honestly): why did we win/lose? What was the real decision driver? Who influenced it? What would have changed the outcome? Log the answers and look for patterns across deals — that pattern is your personal playbook.

Win/loss review — five questions to ask a lost deal

1. "When you look back, what was the single biggest factor in going another way?"
2. "Was there a moment where you leaned toward us? What changed?"
3. "How did we compare on value versus price?"
4. "Was there anyone involved I didn't get to speak with?"
5. "If you were advising me, what's the one thing I should do differently next time?"

Buyers are often surprisingly candid when you ask humbly after a loss. This is free coaching — take it.

Key takeaways: The sale ends when the customer gets value, not at signature. Do a clean, warm handoff to CS with a full note; honour every promise. Prevent buyer's remorse with reassurance and a fast early win. Ask for referrals at the moment of value. Review every win and loss to build your personal playbook.

17. Ethics & Suitability in Financial Services

You are pivoting into finance/fintech, where selling carries extra responsibility. Aggressive tactics that merely annoy in software can cause real harm — and regulatory penalties — in financial services. Internalise these principles now; they will define your reputation.

- **Honesty over the close.** Never overstate capability, returns, or timelines to win a deal. A short-term win built on a false promise becomes a churned customer, a bad reference, and — in regulated products — a complaint.
- **Suitability first (mis-selling is the cardinal sin).** Recommend only what genuinely fits the customer's needs and risk profile. Your NISM training on suitability applies directly: pushing an unsuitable product for commission is mis-selling. In B2B fintech this means not selling an enterprise-priced platform to an SMB that can't absorb it, or promising compliance outcomes you can't guarantee.
- **No fake urgency or scarcity.** Urgency must be real (Section 9). Manufactured pressure is manipulation and, for regulated products sold to consumers, can breach conduct rules.
- **Transparent pricing.** Be clear on total cost, fees, renewal terms, and what's not included. Hidden charges surfacing later destroy trust and invite disputes.
- **Document what you promise.** If you commit to a feature, SLA, or timeline in the sale, put it in writing. This protects the customer and you.
- **Walk away from a bad fit.** The hardest and most valuable ethical muscle: telling a prospect "honestly, we're not the right fit for you right now" when it's true. It costs one deal and earns a lifetime of trust and referrals.

Common trap — winning the deal, losing the customer: Closing something the buyer shouldn't have bought feels like success on signing day and becomes a churn, a refund demand, or a compliance complaint within months. In financial services, sustainable sales careers are built on suitability and honesty, not on maximising this quarter's number at the customer's expense.

Key takeaways: In fintech, ethics is not optional garnish — it's the foundation of a durable career. Sell only what's suitable, never mis-sell for commission, keep urgency and pricing honest, document promises, and be willing to walk away from a bad fit. Reputation compounds faster than any single deal.

18. Master Q&A Bank

Use these to self-test and to prepare for interviews. Model answers are concise; expand them with your own examples.

Q1: What are the six stages of the deal cycle after a meeting is booked?

A: Discovery, Solution/Demo, Proposal/Quote, Negotiation, Close, Handoff. Each has a specific output and requires an agreed dated next step to advance.

Q2: Why is discovery the most important stage?

A: It's the diagnosis; everything downstream (solution, proposal, objection handling, close) is only as good as the discovery. Without it you pitch generic features to unknown pain and lose control of the deal.

Q3: What's a healthy talk-to-listen ratio in discovery, and why?

A: The buyer should talk 60–70%. Your value is your questions and listening, not your monologue; top performers consistently talk less and ask better questions.

Q4: Explain SPIN.

A: Situation (current facts), Problem (difficulties), Implication (consequences/cost of the problem), Need-payoff (value of solving it). Implication grows the pain; Need-payoff makes the buyer articulate the value themselves.

Q5: Which SPIN question type do beginners under-use, and why does it matter?

A: Implication questions. They expand the consequences of the problem and create urgency in rupees. Without them the pain stays small and the buyer feels no reason to act now.

Q6: What is the Pain Funnel?

A: A Sandler question ladder that drives a vague complaint down to a specific, quantified, personal pain — "tell me more," "be specific," "how long," "what have you tried," "did it work," "what's it costing," "how do you feel about it."

Q7: Difference between open and closed questions?

A: Open questions (what/how/why/tell me) invite stories and open topics; closed questions (is/do/how many) pin down facts and confirm. Open to explore, closed to confirm.

Q8: What does BANT stand for?

A: Budget, Authority, Need, Timeline — a lightweight qualifier woven into conversation, not fired as a form.

Q9: What does MEDDIC add over BANT, and when do you use it?

A: Metrics, Economic buyer, Decision criteria, Decision process, Identify pain, Champion. Used for complex enterprise deals with large buying groups (e.g., selling to a bank), where mapping process and champion is critical.

Q10: What is single-threading and why is it dangerous?

A: Relying on one friendly contact and never reaching the economic buyer. The deal dies if that person leaves, is overruled, or lacks authority. Fix by multi-threading — reach the decision-maker and build a champion.

Q11: How should a discovery call end?

A: By playing back the pain, confirming it, and agreeing a specific, dated next step (e.g., a working session with named attendees). Never "I'll send you some info."

Q12: Explain FAB with an example.

A: Feature = what it is ("Aadhaar eKYC API"); Advantage = what it does ("instant verification"); Benefit = why they care ("onboarding drops from 3 days to under an hour, recovering ₹X of lost merchants"). Link with "which means...".

Q13: Why sell benefits over features?

A: Buyers care about outcomes for their pain, not product facts. Features cause objections ("why pay for things we don't need"); benefits tied to their quantified pain drive decisions.

Q14: How do you tailor the same feature to a CFO vs a CTO?

A: CFO: cost, revenue, ROI, payback. CTO: integration, security, uptime, time-to-go-live. Same feature, different benefit framing per persona's priorities.

Q15: Why co-build the ROI with the buyer instead of presenting a slide?

A: Using their input numbers makes the result theirs; they'll defend it internally to the CFO. A business case the champion co-built is far stronger than one you made alone.

Q16: Give the simple ROI and payback formulas.

A: $\text{ROI}\% = (\text{annual gain} - \text{annual cost}) \div \text{annual cost} \times 100$. $\text{Payback (months)} = \text{annual cost} \div \text{monthly gain}$.
 Gain = revenue recovered + cost saved + risk avoided.

Q17: What makes a demo effective?

A: It's tailored proof you solve the specific pain — recap the pain, lead with the biggest pain-solver, use their data/language, pause to check after each moment, and end with a trial close. Not a full feature tour.

Q18: What are the sections of a strong proposal?

A: Executive summary, objectives/success metrics, solution & scope, business case/ROI, timeline/implementation, commercials, proof, next steps. Written so a champion can sell it without you.

Q19: How should you present price?

A: State it clearly, tie it to value ("₹12 lakh against ₹29 lakh recovered"), then stay silent. Don't mumble, apologise, or pre-emptively discount.

Q20: What's the difference between ethical urgency and fake scarcity?

A: Ethical urgency uses the buyer's real deadlines and real cost-of-delay. Fake scarcity invents phantom deadlines or buyers — it works once, then destroys trust, and in regulated sales can be misconduct.

Q21: Is an objection a bad sign?

A: No — it's engagement. A buyer who objects is still in the conversation. The silent "I'll get back to you" is the real danger. Objections are requests for information or reassurance.

Q22: What does a price objection usually really mean?

A: A value objection in disguise — the buyer doesn't yet see enough value to justify the number. Reframe to ROI rather than immediately discounting.

Q23: Walk through the ACRC objection method.

A: Acknowledge (lower temperature), Clarify (find the real concern with a question), Respond (address it with value/proof), Confirm (check it's resolved and move forward). Never skip Clarify.

Q24: What is Feel-Felt-Found and when do you use it?

A: An empathy pattern — "I understand how you feel; others felt the same; what they found was...". Good for emotional or "happy with current" objections. Use genuinely and sparingly since it's well-known.

Q25: A buyer says "just send me an email." What do you do?

A: Re-engage: "Happy to — so I send the right thing, not a generic deck, can I ask two quick questions?" Turn the brush-off back into discovery rather than sending info into a void.

Q26: "I need to think about it." Your response?

A: "Of course — so I'm useful, what specifically do you want to think through? Usually it's price, fit, or timing — which is it?" Surface the hidden concern instead of accepting the stall.

Q27: Difference between a position and an interest?

A: A position is what they say they want ("20% off"); an interest is why ("a fixed budget cap" or "a win to show my boss"). Positions clash; interests can be reconciled. Always dig from position to interest.

Q28: Define BATNA and ZOPA.

A: BATNA = Best Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement (your walk-away option, your power). ZOPA = Zone Of Possible Agreement (the overlap where a deal is possible). Know both yours and theirs.

Q29: Why not accept a buyer's low anchor?

A: The first credible number frames the whole negotiation. Accepting a lowball lets it pull the outcome down. Re-anchor to value instead; silence looks like agreement.

Q30: What's the golden rule of concessions?

A: Never give without getting. Trade every concession with "if/then" (e.g., "if you sign 2 years and be a reference, then 10% off"). Give reluctantly and in shrinking amounts.

Q31: How do you handle procurement?

A: Win the business sponsor first so procurement negotiates the how not the whether; leave negotiating room; trade every concession; protect your walk-away; counter last-minute "nibbles" with a trade. Don't take the squeeze personally — it's their job.

Q32: What is the discount trap?

A: Giving price away (often unprompted, to relieve deadline anxiety) to close. It trains buyers to always push, kills margin, and signals the original price was fake. Only discount with a trade and in shrinking amounts.

Q33: Name three buying signals.

A: Ownership language ("when can we go live?"), detailed implementation/contract questions, and bringing in other stakeholders. Also price/terms questions and positive non-verbals.

Q34: What is a trial close and why use it?

A: A low-pressure temperature check ("on a 1–10, how good a fit is this?"). It surfaces objections early so nothing ambushes you at signature.

Q35: Name four closing techniques.

A: Assumptive (proceed as if yes), Summary (recap value then ask), Alternative (offer two yeses), Urgency/event (tie to a real deadline). Also direct ask and pilot/puppy-dog close. Ethical only when the fit is genuine.

Q36: What's the number-one reason beginners lose winnable deals at the end?

A: They never actually ask for the business — they end with "let me know what you think." You must explicitly ask (assumptive/alternative/direct) and then stay silent.

Q37: What is a Mutual Action Plan?

A: A shared, dated checklist of every step to go-live with owners on both sides (security review, legal, procurement, PO, kickoff, go-live). It de-risks the close and exposes hidden steps early.

Q38: Why does the handoff to Customer Success matter?

A: The sale is only done when the customer gets value. A clean, warm handoff with a full note (pain, promises, stakeholders, landmines) prevents the customer re-explaining, reduces buyer's remorse, and protects renewal.

Q39: How and when do you ask for referrals?

A: At the moment of value, tied to a specific result: "drop-off is down to 4% — who else in your network has this problem? I'll draft the intro." Make it effortless.

Q40: What is mis-selling and why does it matter more in finance?

A: Selling a product that doesn't suit the customer's needs/risk profile, often for commission. In financial services it causes real harm and regulatory penalties (ties to NISM suitability principles). Sustainable careers are built on suitability and honesty, not maximising this quarter's number.

Q41: When should you walk away from a deal?

A: When it isn't a genuine fit — an SMB that can't absorb an enterprise product, or when you'd have to over-promise. Saying "we're not the right fit" costs one deal and earns lasting trust and referrals.

Q42: Give a one-line summary of the whole deal cycle philosophy.

A: Diagnose before you prescribe, sell value not price, trade never gift, ask for the business, and only close what's genuinely right for the customer.

Final key takeaways: Master discovery and the rest follows. Sell quantified benefits tied to real pain. Handle objections with Acknowledge-Clarify-Respond-Confirm. Negotiate interests, trade every concession, and re-anchor lowballs. Read buying signals, run trial closes, and always explicitly ask for the business. Hand off cleanly, review every win and loss, and never mis-sell — in fintech, your reputation is the asset that compounds.